CHAPTER 11

The Rise and Fall of alias_method_chain

In the previous two chapters, we looked at the modular design of Rails and how that design changed over time. Now I'll tell you of a more dramatic change in Rails' history: how a method named alias_method_chain rose to fame, fell in disgrace, and was eventually scrapped almost entirely from the Rails codebase.

The Rise of alias_method_chain

In *The Include-and-Extend Trick*, on page 179, I showed you a snippet of code from an old version of Rails…minus a few interesting lines. Here is the same code again, with those lines now visible and marked with arrows:

gems/activerecord-2.3.2/lib/active_record/validations.rb

```
module ActiveRecord
  module Validations

    def self.included(base)
      base.extend ClassMethods
➤     base.class_eval do
➤       alias_method_chain :save, :validation
➤       alias_method_chain :save!, :validation
➤     end

      # ...

    end
```

When ActiveRecord::Base includes the Validations module, the marked lines reopen Base and call a method named alias_method_chain. Let me show you a quick example to explain what alias_method_chain does.